

The Universal Layering Cheat Sheet

One page. Every trip. Match what the day is doing to what goes on your back.

Nobody turns back because of the weather.

They turn back because they're wet, or cold, or carrying twice what they needed. All three are decisions made the night before — and all three are fixable in about a minute with the table below.

READ THE DAY → WEAR THIS

CONDITIONS	WEAR	WHY IT MATTERS
Clear, mild, calm	Base only	Keep the shell in a pocket — weather turns fastest when it looks settled.
Clear, mild, windy	Base + Shell	Skip the mid layer while you're moving; wind steals heat, effort makes it.
Cool, calm	Base + Mid	Shed the mid layer the moment you start climbing, not after you're damp.
Cool/cold + wind or rain	All 3 layers	Shell goes on before you're wet. Over damp layers it barely helps.
Cold, exposed ridge	All 3 + extremities	Hat, gloves and dry socks decide this one — not the jacket.

THE ONE RULE THAT REPLACES THE TABLE

Start every hike slightly cold. If you're comfortable standing at the trailhead, you're overdressed for moving.



Same pack, every trip — what changes is which layer is on you.

Turn over for the three-layer system and the mistakes it prevents.

THE SYSTEM BEHIND THE TABLE

Three layers. One decision each.

Learn this once and you'll never need a packing list for clothing again — you'll be able to build one for any trip, in any season, from the forecast alone.

BASE

Against your skin, every single trip. Its one job is moving sweat out so it can evaporate. Cotton does the opposite — it holds water against you and pulls heat out four times faster than dry fabric.

MID

Your insulation, and the layer people get wrong on timing rather than choice. On at rest stops and summits. Off the moment you're climbing hard enough to make your own heat.

SHELL

Blocks wind and rain, lets your heat escape. Ridgelines run 10–15°F colder and windier than the trailhead — which is why it's worth carrying on a clear forecast.

WHAT THIS FIXES

You were warm at the car

Comfortable standing still means overdressed for moving. Ten minutes into the first climb you're sweating into the layer meant to keep you warm later.

The forecast said the valley

Trailhead numbers don't describe the ridge. Elevation and wind do more to how cold you feel than the temperature on your phone.

You packed for every scenario

Three jackets 'just in case' is a heavy pack and a short trip. One versatile layer system covers more conditions than three single-purpose ones.



The full guide also covers what to eat — real cooking, under 15 minutes, one pot.

You've got the rule. TrailReady gives you the whole trip.

Five trip types — day hike, overnight backpacking, car camping, cold-weather and wet-weather — each with what to wear, a tap-to-check packing list, a quick recipe, and what to do when you're caught without the right layer. Plus a spreadsheet that turns your trip and the forecast into a layering list for you.

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